

BETWEEN THE WARS

Ambitious plans for the production and use of tanks were dramatically reduced at the end of World War I, but theories for the vehicle's future role proliferated. Some military thinkers believed tanks could and should replace all other types of forces; some felt trench warfare would never be seen again and that the tank was no longer necessary.

The mechanical reliability of tanks improved greatly during this period. This encouraged both theorists and practitioners to consider faster paced and more mobile concepts of operations. Britain led the way at this time, establishing her Experimental Mechanised Force—the first large formation used to test theories of armored warfare—in 1927.

Development varied between nations. Britain decided it needed two types of tank—one for infantry support and the other a mobile replacement for cavalry, roles that required very different designs. Germany was forbidden tanks until 1933, so those it built were constructed in secret and tested in the Soviet Union. Armored warfare theories in Germany were based around balanced all-arms mechanized formations operating at high speed. After many years restricted to just the FT, during the 1930s France produced several new tanks for a variety of roles, while the Soviet Union, usually taking foreign designs as a starting point, manufactured thousands of vehicles and developed a doctrine based on high mobility.

During the 1930s, as war began to seem more likely and older tanks reached the end of their lives, a new generation of tanks began to enter service around the world. Many of these vehicles would soon see action.



△ "Spain Resurrected"

A Spanish nationalist poster celebrates the end of the Spanish Civil War, which saw tanks being used in blitzkrieg fashion for the first time.

"... the tankers have **destroyed** at Teruel no fewer than 1,000 **fascist troops**... our powerful **tank cannons** have relentlessly forced [them] out of the **trenches**."

SOVIET COLONEL S. A. KONDRATIEV, DURING THE SPANISH CIVIL WAR, 1937

◁ A Spanish Republican poster waxes lyrical about the tank in 1936.

- ▷ **July 1919** Four Medium Cs take part in the World War I Victory Parade in London, despite not fighting in the war.
- ▷ **1920** French and American tank units are both placed under the control of their Infantry Branch.
- ▷ **1923** The British Government's Department of Tank Design is shut down. Tank development becomes the responsibility of private industry.
- ▷ **1923** The British Royal Tank Corps is formed as a separate branch of service. The first of 166 Vickers Mediums are delivered, the most widely produced tank of the 1920s.
- ▷ **1929** The Kama Tank School is established at Kazan, in the Soviet Union, allowing Germany to carry out tank development and training.
- ▷ **1931** The job of developing mechanization within the US Army is assigned to the Cavalry Branch.
- ▷ **1931** The French Army introduces the D1, its first new tank since 1918.



△ **Japanese tankettes**

The Japanese used thousands of tanks, but most were light vehicles that emphasized mobility over armor.

- ▷ **October 1935** The first three German Panzer Divisions are formed.
- ▷ **1935** A Soviet Mechanized Corps of over 1,000 tanks takes part in an exercise at Kiev.
- ▷ **1936** The Spanish Civil War breaks out; Germany, Italy, and the Soviet Union send their latest tanks to fight.